

music lessons and a piano was brought into the house, and it was not until 1911 that George began learning the piano, too. He quickly became a proficient pianist, with a love of classical music, but within a couple of years took up a career in the popular music business. He left school in 1913, aged 15, to become a “song plugger”: a pianist that was employed by the publishers and music sellers of Tin Pan Alley to play the latest tunes to attract buyers of sheet music.

Here he learned his songwriting craft and, as well as demonstrating the hit tunes of the day, he wrote some of his own, getting the first of these published in 1916. He began work at the Aeolian Company, recording and arranging songs. With the advent of gramophones, radio, and later the talking pictures, the music industry was on the cusp of great change, and Gershwin was well placed to be at the forefront of this new golden age of popular song (see [box](#)).

